

Day 6 — Ahāra (Food)

Module: Ayurveda (Middle) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students name the six tastes (*rasa*) in Ayurveda, the recommended meal-timing principle, and one food pairing tradition recommends avoiding.

Materials

- 6 taste samples if available (salt for salty, lemon for sour, jaggery for sweet, mint for bitter, ginger for pungent, raw banana or persimmon for astringent)
- Whiteboard

Vocabulary

- *Ahāra* — food
- *Rasa* — taste (also: essence)
- *Madhura*, *amla*, *lavaṇa*, *kaṭu*, *tikta*, *kaṣāya* — sweet, sour, salty, pungent, bitter, astringent

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Daily prompt + recall: dinacharya principle.

Core (25 min)

1. **The Six Tastes** (*rasa*):

Sanskrit	English	Examples	Dosha effect
Madhura	Sweet	Rice, milk, sugar, fruit	↓ Vāta, ↓ Pitta, ↑ Kapha
Amla	Sour	Citrus, yogurt, vinegar	↓ Vāta, ↑ Pitta, ↑ Kapha
Lavaṇa	Salty	Salt, sea vegetables	↓ Vāta, ↑ Pitta, ↑ Kapha
Kaṭu	Pungent	Chili, ginger, garlic	↑ Vāta, ↑ Pitta, ↓ Kapha
Tikta	Bitter	Bitter gourd, turmeric, neem	↑ Vāta, ↓ Pitta, ↓ Kapha
Kaṣāya	Astringent	Banana (unripe), pomegranate, beans	↑ Vāta, ↓ Pitta, ↓ Kapha

2. **The principle:** a balanced meal includes ALL six tastes. Traditional Indian thalis are designed this way — you'll notice rice (sweet), pickle (sour/salty), chili (pungent), bitter gourd or fenugreek (bitter), and a pulse-based dish (astringent).

3. Meal timing:

- Largest meal at midday (Pitta peak — digestion strongest).
- Light dinner before sunset (ideally).
- No heavy meal close to bedtime.

4. **One food rule:** *Virrudha-ahāra* — incompatible food combinations. Classical examples:

- Milk + fish (heating + cooling combination).
- Milk + sour fruit (digestive disturbance).
- Honey heated above body temperature (changes its qualities).

Note: some virrudha-ahāra rules have modern evidence (e.g. some lactose-fruit-acid interactions); others are traditional with limited validation.

Activity (10 min) — Taste tour

If samples available: tiny sample of each taste, one at a time. Note the sensation. Note what dosha it would affect.

If no samples: students list 3 foods they ate in the last 24 hours and identify which tastes were present + missing.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 7: “*Tomorrow — primary source. BG 6.17.*”

Homework

- For tomorrow’s meals, count how many of the six tastes you include. Aim for at least 4.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read about the six-taste theory in Caraka Saṃhitā Sūtra-sthāna chapter 26.
- **Tier down:** Memorise just 4 tastes (sweet, sour, salty, bitter).

Teacher notes

- Skip the taste samples if allergies are a concern.
- The “milk + fish” rule is famous; honest framing: some virrudha-ahāra has biochemical basis, some is traditional. Don’t overstate either way.

Citation(s) used

- Caraka Saṃhitā Sūtra-sthāna ch. 26 — Sharma (1981) translation.
- Wujastyk (2003) on the six tastes.